Douglas SBD-3 Dauntless

The US Navy's main dive-bomber at the start of the war, the Dauntless, based on the Northrop BT-1, was the best available and performed excellent service as a bomber and reconnaissance aircraft. The SBD-3 first entered service in March 1941, and in May and June 1942, during the battles of the Coral Sea and Midway, Dauntless squadrons sank five Japanese aircraft carriers, changing the course of the war in the Pacific. The aircraft carried a much heavier bombload than its Japanese counterpart, and its vulnerability to fighters was compensated for by its ability to absorb damage – it had the lowest loss rate of any US Pacific carrier type. Nearly 6,000 Dauntlesses were built, sinking more Japanese ships than any other Allied weapon.

Engine 1,000hp Wright R-1820-52 Cyclone 9-cylinder radial

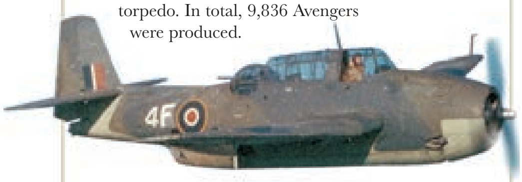
Wingspan 45ft 6in (13.9m) **Length** 33ft 1in (10.1m)

Top speed 250mph (402kph) **Crew** 2

Armament 2 x .5in machine guns in nose, 2 x .3in machine guns in rear cockpit; 1,200lb (545kg) bombload

Grumman TBM Avenger

Grumman named its new torpedo-bomber for the US Navy "Avenger" (TBM-1 with British marking shown), on the day that the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor brought the US into WWII. It proved to be just that, playing a major part in the sinking of over 60 ships of the Imperial Japanese Navy. Two features made the Avenger outstanding. It was the first single-engined American aircraft to incorporate a power-operated gun turret, and the first to carry the heavy 22in (577mm) torpedo. In total, 9,836 Avengers were produced.



Engine 1,900hp Wright R-2600-20 Cyclone 14-cylinder radial

Wingspan 54ft 2in (16.5m) **Length** 40ft 11in (12.5m)

Top speed 276mph (444kph) **Crew** 3

Armament 4 x .5in machine guns; 2,000lb (907kg) bombload, or 1 x 22in (577mm) torpedo and 8 x 5in (12.7cm) rockets

Grumman F6F-5 Hellcat

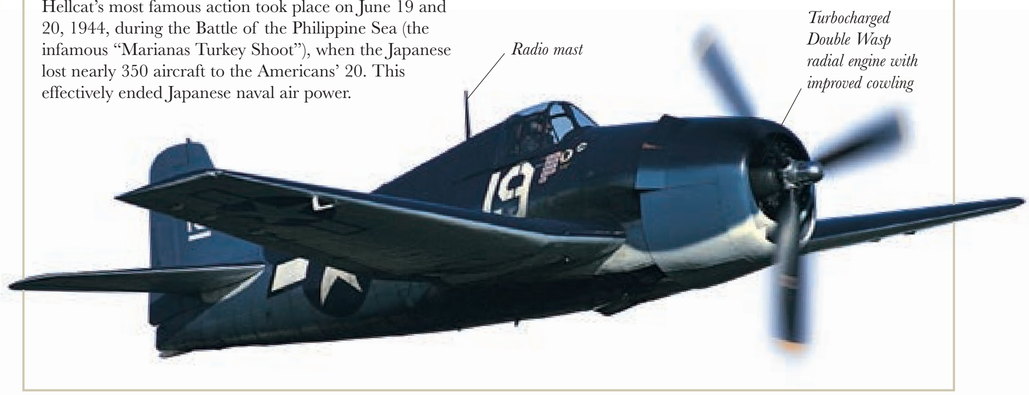
When Grumman designed a replacement for the Wildcat, it consulted the pilots and produced the F6F, to the same formula but with more of everything. The engine was nearly twice as powerful, more ammunition and fuel were carried, and it was covered in over 200lb (91kg) of armor plate. In service from January 1943, the Hellcat's most famous action took place on June 19 and 20, 1944, during the Battle of the Philippine Sea (the infamous "Marianas Turkey Shoot"), when the Japanese lost nearly 350 aircraft to the Americans' 20. This effectively ended Japanese naval air power.

Engine 2,000hp Pratt and Whitney R2800-10W 18-cylinder radial

Wingspan 42ft 10in (13.1m) **Length** 33ft 7in (10.2m)

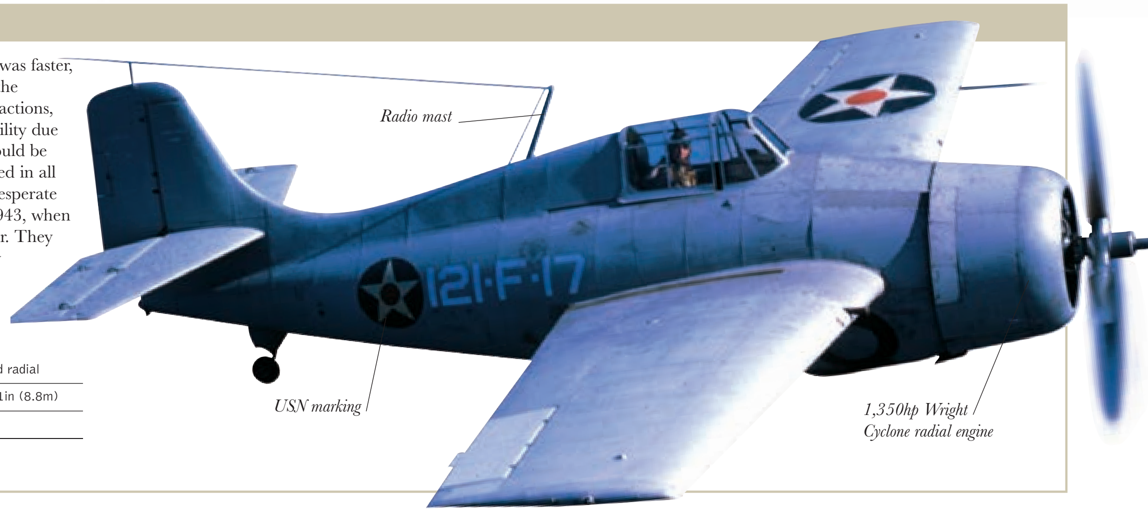
Top speed 380mph (612kph) **Crew** 1

Armament 6 x .5in machine guns; 2,000lb (907kg) bombload, 6 x 5in (12.7cm) rockets



Grumman F4F Wildcat

At the outbreak of war, the Japanese "Zero" was faster, more maneuverable, and better armed than the Wildcat. US pilots, in many heroic defensive actions, found their airplane's one advantage – durability due to armor plate and self-sealing fuel tanks – could be used to defeat the Zero. Wildcats were involved in all major actions in the Pacific – including the desperate fighting on Guadalcanal – until the end of 1943, when they were replaced by the Hellcat and Corsair. They also operated from small US and Royal Navy convoy escort carriers in the Atlantic, in antisubmarine teams with torpedo-bombers.



Engine 1,200hp P&W R1830-86 Twin Wasp air-cooled radial

Wingspan 38ft (11.6m) **Length** 28ft 11in (8.8m)

Top speed 318mph (512kph) **Crew** 1

Armament 6 x .5in machine guns in wings